

mice with built-in wheels that can be used to scroll through large display windows.

For many years, the design of computer keyboards remained relatively standard: alphanumeric keys arranged in traditional QWERTY fashion with some additional, computer-specific keys. Newer keyboards reflect concerns such as ergonomics. 'Natural' keyboards, for example, divide the familiar horizontal rows of keys into two discrete vertical halves, which allow you to type with your arms at a more comfortable angle. Many keyboards provide wrist support. Some include built-in pointing devices—usually a touch pad. Clearly, input devices have changed in recent years—both in looks and in technologies. This review will help you choose one that matches your personal needs and preferences.

MICE

We tested 27 mice that covered regular mice along with optical ones.

Build quality

Input devices tend to get roughed up while being used, so they need to be sturdy. The **Microsoft Intellimouse** did very well here. There wasn't a single crack or any deformation in this device. The same goes for the Trackman Marble FX that cakewalked through this test. Other contenders who passed the test with flying colours included the Anubis Autoscroll mouse, Maple Wheel 3D mouse, Typhoon 3D optical mouse, and Maple Scrolltrack 4D.

Performance

People who are into gaming or hardcore graphics love the precision that a high-resolution mouse provides. The **Logitech Wheel Mouse** optical proved to be a laudable performer here—it felt great while playing games and also while editing images. For the low-end user the Maple Eagle mouse is a good choice at a resolution of 520 dpi. The Microsoft Intellimouse is good enough for gaming and image-editing but sometimes loses track while executing quick movements. The Maple 2Wheel 4D mouse also proved to be good in this area with acceptable precision.

Mention must be made of the Logitech cordless MouseMan wheel, which was very precise in its movements not only in normal Windows use but also in hardcore

The system used to evaluate the input devices consisted of a Celeron 466-based computer with 64 MB SDRAM. The operating system was Windows 98 SE, loaded on a cleanly formatted system. The drivers of each device were loaded as the testing was done, and uninstalled before connecting the next one. This was to ensure that the drivers didn't conflict with one another.

Mice

We tested each mouse for its build quality and features. We also took into consideration its customisability. Extra features were rated for the amount of help they provided, not just for mere presence. If the mouse was detected and installed auto-

gaming. The Logitech Trackman Marble FX also is very good for the precision-minded user, though playing games can be a bit tricky. The mice that were low on precision were the Typhoon Scroll Mouse 4D, Anubis Mouse Mena 2 and Turbo Mouse 911. These mice went off track quite often during heavy image editing and fast gaming.

Features

The Microsoft Intellimouse doesn't disappoint in features. It lets you effortlessly breeze through the Net, and all your work and entertainment applications. It works on almost any surface and stays precise because there are no moving parts. It is also very easy to install—just plug it into the USB port and it automatically gets detected. The buttons could have been placed in a better way though. For instance, the thumb button could be placed a bit lower, to make the device more comfortable to use.

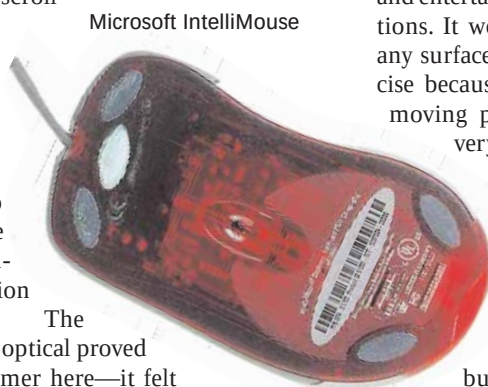
The Trackman Marble FX has a sensor that records the position of the ball many times per second by continuously bouncing light off the red sphere. The four buttons can be configured with the installed program to be any key on the keyboard, or other useful commands (double-click, drag lock, etc). These 'extra' buttons were found to be quite practical, saving some time and

TEST PROCESS

atically, extra points were awarded. The most important factor considered was the ergonomics and the feel of the device. To test the sturdiness of the devices, we decided to do a 'drop test' on the mice by dropping it from six feet.

Keyboards

Comfort is the 'key' thing here, because the keyboard is a component that is generally used for long periods of time. The position of the wrists when it rests on the keyboard is very important, so is the layout of keys. We also looked at the quality of keystrokes. The smoothness and placement of important keys and shortcut keys, and sturdiness were also taken into consideration.



Microsoft IntelliMouse